Jean-Michel Basquiat

Groove Nomad · Beyond the music · summary of the 4 research files (11 Nov 2026)

Who he is, in three lines

- Born 22 Dec 1960 in Brooklyn, died 12 Aug 1988 in Manhattan, aged 27. Haitian father, Puerto Rican mother, grew up speaking English, French and Spanish.
- Started as **SAMO©** (1977–80) with Al Díaz: short, sharp phrases sprayed on Lower Manhattan walls. It ended with “SAMO is dead”.
- Went from the street to the galleries in about two years, then to the world. One of the best-known painters of the 80s.

The story, step by step

- **1968** hit by a car at 7. In hospital his mother gave him *Gray’s Anatomy*: bodies, bones and skulls stay in his work for life.
- **1978–79** leaves home, sells hand-painted postcards and T-shirts in Washington Square Park.
- **1980** *Times Square Show*: first big exhibition, first mention in *Artforum*.
- **1981** *New York/New Wave* at P.S. 1 (15 Feb–5 Apr, curated by Diego Cortez). Graffiti writers and artists together. **Lady Pink was in it too.** René Ricard writes “The Radiant Child” in *Artforum* (Dec).
- **1982** first New York solo show (Annina Nosei gallery) and Documenta 7 in Kassel, at 21.
- **1982–85** friendship and joint paintings with Andy Warhol. Close to Keith Haring.
- **1983** Whitney Biennial. Paints *Museum Security (Broadway Meltdown)* in Los Angeles.

The hip-hop link (the reason he is in our magazine)

- **Beat Bop (1983)**: he produced and paid for the single by **Rammellzee & K-Rob**, on his own label Tartown, and drew the black-and-white sleeve. He is credited as producer, not as rapper. One source says about 500 copies were pressed.
- **Blondie, “Rapture” (1981)**: plays the DJ in the video, in place of Grandmaster Flash, who did not show up. Fab 5 Freddy and Lee Quiñones are in it too.
- **Fab 5 Freddy** was the bridge between the Bronx/Harlem hip-hop scene and downtown art. Rammellzee, Futura and Dondi were peers.
- He did not want to be labelled “graffiti artist”: he wanted to be seen as a painter.

Women around his work

- **Lady Pink**: exhibited with him in *New York/New Wave* (1981). Our link with the previous page.
- **Suzanne Mallouk**: partner and muse, about 1981–83. Her memories are the base of Jennifer Clement’s book *Widow Basquiat* (not a neutral biography).

- **Paige Powell**: partner and photographer, documented his studio life and the Warhol years (one dossier only).
- **Annina Nosei**: his first New York dealer, gave him a studio under her gallery.
- **Debbie Harry**: Blondie's singer, from the "Rapture" video.

Legacy and numbers

- **1992–93** Whitney Museum retrospective, first big museum one after his death.
- **2017** *Untitled* (1982, skull) sold for **$110.5 million** at Sotheby's (buyer Yusaku Maezawa): record for an American artist at that time.
- **2022–23** *King Pleasure*, curated by his family: 200+ works in New York, then Los Angeles; the Estate says 300,000+ visitors in total.
- **14 May 2026** *Museum Security (Broadway Meltdown)* sold for **$52.7 million** at Sotheby's New York (checked by me online).
- Still true in 2026? The $110.5M record needs a last check before printing.

Fashion

- **1987** he walked for Rei Kawakubo's **Comme des Garçons** in Paris. Sources disagree on the season (SS87 or SS88), so we write only "1987, Paris".
- He painted in expensive suits (Armani, Issey Miyake) and went barefoot on a 1985 *New York Times Magazine* cover. Style was part of his image.
- **Tiffany "About Love" (2021)**: campaign with Beyoncé and JAY-Z in front of *Equals Pi*. Authorised by the Estate, and criticised by some.
- **Brand lists do not agree** (Coach, Uniqlo, Supreme, Lee, Saint Laurent, Dr. Martens: different years in different files). We name none of them except Tiffany.

Where the 4 files disagree (and what I do)

Point	What the files say	What we write
End of SAMO	late 1979 / 1980	"1980"
Madonna	one file: well documented; another: weak	Leave out
Jennifer Stein	one file: collaborator; another: not verifiable	Leave out
Documenta 7	"youngest" / "one of the youngest"	"one of the youngest"
Guggenheim "Defacement"	2017 / 2019	Leave out or check
Fashion brands	years and brands differ	Only Comme des Garçons and Tiffany
Rammellzee v Basquiat	one source: they refused his vocals	Leave out (one source)
P.S. 1 in 1981	now called MoMA PS1	Write "P.S. 1"

Quotes we can use (short)

- “Royalty, heroism, and the streets.” (Basquiat on his subjects; Interview magazine 1983, one file says c.1985: check)
- René Ricard’s title “The Radiant Child” (*Artforum*, Dec 1981).

Photos and permission

- All his paintings, drawings, the **Beat Bop sleeve** and details of them are copyright of the Estate. Licence needed: **Artestar**, reproductions@artestar.com, tel. (212) 627-7242.
- Photos of him: rights-managed. Names given: Tseng Kwong Chi, Edo Bertoglio, Paige Powell, Glen E. Friedman, James Van Der Zee.
- Do not use Pinterest, blogs, auction pages or YouTube screenshots as “cleared”.

Watch and listen

- *Jean-Michel Basquiat: The Radiant Child* (2010, Tamra Davis).
- *Boom for Real: The Late Teenage Years of Jean-Michel Basquiat* (2017, Sara Driver).
- *Downtown 81* (shot 1980–81, released 2000), Basquiat plays himself.
- *Beat Bop* on the MoMA record page: moma.org/collection/works/177362. Official links to documentaries: not verified.